2-1 Research findings

Define the future user journey experience we are working towards in 2025.

TLDR: Through deep discovery with our Partners, PS Team and competitive research, we validated the **Hybrid prototype** as the best path forward—balancing native functionality with seamless integrations to support a range of inventory needs. We're not just building a competitive solution, but one that's practical, scalable, and strategically positioned for growth in 2025 and beyond.

Overview

As part of our efforts to reimagine Method's inventory management experience for 2025, we explored two distinct prototype approaches: **Native** and **Hybrid**. Each is designed to meet the evolving needs of our customer base, particularly those operating in complex, inventory-driven environments like Manufacturing, Wholesale & Distribution (MWD).

Prototype Options

Native Prototype

TLDR: Designed as a native inventory management system (IMS) built directly within Method with advanced, out-of-the-box features—eliminating the need for customizations to manage inventory.

This prototype represents our vision for a fully in-house inventory solution built directly into Method.

This solution focuses on:

- Delivering a robust, real-time inventory solution that minimizes manual work.
- Standardizing advanced inventory functionalities and more as part of the core offering to eliminate the need for costly add-on customizations.
- Enhancing the user experience with intuitive, flexible item management that aligns with modern operational demands.
- Becoming the single source of truth for inventory data.

Prototype Link

Hybrid Prototype

TLDR: A flexible inventory management solution that combines core out-of-the-box features with third-party integrations—designed to support a broader range of workflows.

This prototype offers a flexible foundation by delivering essential inventory features natively, while enabling users to connect with third-party systems for more advanced capabilities.

This solution focuses on:

- Providing a scalable path for businesses—allowing them to start with essential out-of-the-box functionality and layer on advanced capabilities via integration as their needs evolve.
  - Or for companies that already use external inventory systems or have complex operational requirements that go beyond what a native solution can deliver alone.
- Delivering a robust, real-time inventory solution that minimizes manual work and seamless integrates with external systems.
- Standardizing advanced inventory functionalities as part of the core offering to eliminate the need for costly add-on customizations.
- Enhancing the user experience with intuitive, flexible item management that aligns with modern operational demands.
- Becoming the central connected hub for inventory.

Prototype Link

Learning from the Field:

To better understand the real-world challenges our customers face with inventory management, we explored the custom solutions the PS team implemented for various clients—each reflecting different levels of inventory complexity and integration needs.

Our goal was to uncover recurring **pain points**, understand the **day-to-day workflows** driving these custom builds, and evaluate **why and when integrations with third-party systems became necessary**. These conversations helped ground our prototypes in real customer scenarios and shaped our thinking around where native functionality should stop and where integrations should start.

Native-Only Workflows: Customization as a Survival Tool

Viedera and **Euroboor** shared workflows that were entirely built within Method, opting to avoid third-party systems in favour of reducing tool sprawl and maintaining centralized control.

Viedera

Pain Point:

Viedera was unable to effectively manage and track inventory across multiple warehouses, which resulted in inaccuracies and potential errors. This was primarily due to the lack of real-time visibility and automated updates, making it difficult to maintain accurate inventory levels and coordinate across locations.

Solution:

The solution introduced manual warehouse tracking within Method, using custom fields and a manual "update warehouse" button to keep quantities in sync. Though functional, it required strict user discipline to prevent errors and ensure timely updates.

Workflow

1. **Customization:** Custom fields and screens are created in Method to manage inventory by warehouse.
2. **Transaction Creation:** Users create transactions (e.g., sales orders) and select the warehouse for each line item or for the entire transaction.
3. **Manual Update:** After transactions are created, users must manually click an "update warehouse" button to adjust inventory levels in Method, ensuring quantities are accurate.
   - The action can only be performed once per day or once per transaction
   - QBO inventory updates but not warehouse specific inventory resulting in manual updates
4. **Verification:** Users verify that the quantities in the custom fields match the actual quantities in QuickBooks.
5. **Handling Changes:** If an invoice is deleted or modified, users must manually adjust the inventory levels to reflect these changes.
6. **Regular Checks:** Users perform regular checks and updates to ensure the accuracy of inventory levels across different warehouses.

Euroboor

Pain Point:

Euroboor struggled with inadequate inventory management features in both QBO and Method. They needed a solution that could handle advanced inventory functions. Without these capabilities, they faced challenges in managing inventory allocations and accurately tracking inventory movements, leading to inefficiencies and potential errors.

Solution:

The solution involved building out a full suite of custom inventory management features inside Method. However, it surfaced several limitations, such as serial number handling, allocation timing, and the absence of dynamic syncing.

Workflows

Inventory Record Management:

- Select an item to view its inventory details, including description, class, serial number, location site, bin, and quantity.
- Manage inventory allocation, with the option to transfer inventory to new locations by providing a new destination site and bin.
- An audit record is created upon saving inventory changes to track adjustments.

Invoice and Inventory Allocation:

- Invoices are initially read-only; users must explicitly choose to edit inventory lines.
- Upon editing, inventory is deallocated and then reallocated when saving or locking the invoice lines.
- Source inventory is filtered based on the selected item, showing site, bin, and quantity.

Back Order Management:

- If insufficient inventory is available, users are prompted to create back orders.
- Back-ordered items are tracked on a separate tab, allowing users to create new invoices or eliminate back-order flags.

Batch Inventory Entry:

- Users select multiple items to create inventory entries in bulk, replacing the need for a dedicated receiving process.
- Specify quantity, site, bin, and additional notes for audit purposes.
- Duplicate lines for items with unique serial numbers if needed.

Inventory Merge and Transfer:

- When transferring inventory, the system checks for existing records at the destination site and bin.
- If a record exists, it suggests merging; otherwise, a new record is created.
- Serial number limitations require individual handling to maintain uniqueness.

These workflows reinforced that, while Method can be stretched to accommodate complex needs, doing so requires significant customization effort, rigorous user training, and often

workarounds that could otherwise be avoided with more robust out-of-the-box functionality.

Hybrid Workflows: When Integration Becomes a Necessity

SLE Technologies and **Cypress Engine** shared cases where integrations with SOS Inventory were implemented to address the limitations of Method's native capabilities—particularly around multi-warehouse management, real-time visibility, and sales order tracking.

SLE Technologies

Pain Point:

The customer struggled with the lack of real-time inventory tracking and the ability to manage multiple warehouses, which caused delays and potential inaccuracies. This lack of visibility negatively impacted decision-making and disrupted overall business operations.

Solution:

The solution introduced an integration with SOS along with a button-based workflow to view inventory by warehouse, with periodic app routines syncing data between Method, SOS, and QuickBooks. However, due to data processing limitations, updates were delayed and only triggered a few times daily.

Workflow

Method > SOS > QBO circular sync process

1. **Sales Order Creation:** A sales order is created in Method.
2. **Inventory Check:** Users can view inventory levels by warehouse using a button labeled "view by warehouse," which shows available quantities in each warehouse.
   - SOS Inventory provides the ability to sort and view inventory by warehouse location.
   - This data is then synced to Method, allowing users to see which warehouse an item is in and the quantity available.
   - However, the actual selection of which warehouse to deduct items from is managed within SOS, not Method.
3. **Sync to SOS:** Upon saving the sales order, it is sent to SOS Inventory to update and remove the item from stock.
   - An API app routine sends data from Method to SOS Inventory
4. **Sync to QuickBooks:** SOS then syncs with QuickBooks, which eventually updates Method with the latest inventory data.
5. **Inventory Updates:** The inventory data is updated three times a day or manually using a button (approx. 2-3hrs) that triggers a routine to refresh inventory levels.

- The app routines play a crucial role in updating inventory data. They are used to refresh inventory levels in Method by retrieving data from SOS Inventory.
- The routines check the quantity on hand for each item and update a custom field in Method to reflect current inventory levels.
- However, due to the large number of items, these routines can take a significant amount of time to complete.

Cypress Engine

Pain Point:

The main challenge was that Method lacked the necessary inventory capabilities, forcing the company to rely on SOS Inventory to manage their specific inventory needs.

Solution:

The solution took it a step further—SOS became the source of truth, handling all transactions while Method remained focused on CRM.

Workflow

1. **Sales Pipeline in Method:** The company uses Method to manage their sales pipeline, handling tasks like tracking leads and customer interactions.
2. **Sales Order Creation in SOS:** Sales order is created directly in SOS Inventory, as it handles all sales orders, estimates, and invoices.
3. **Data Transfer via API:** Initially, the plan was to use an API to transfer sales order data from Method to SOS Inventory. However, since SOS handles all sales-related tasks, this step became unnecessary.
4. **Inventory Management in SOS:** SOS Inventory manages all inventory-related tasks, including tracking inventory levels, sales orders, and custom fields that are not available in QuickBooks.
5. **Scheduled Updates:** Data synchronization between Method and SOS occurs every two hours to ensure that Method has the latest information from SOS Inventory.
6. **Manual Update Option:** If a sales rep needs more immediate information (SOS fields for transactions not inventory related), they can manually trigger an update by clicking an "Update from SOS" button in Method, which retrieves the latest transaction data from SOS.
   - **Initiate Update:** The sales rep identifies a transaction in Method that requires the latest information from SOS Inventory.
   - **Click Update Button:** The sales rep clicks the designated "Update from SOS" button within the Method interface.

- **API Call:** This action triggers an API call to SOS Inventory, requesting the latest data for the specific transaction.
- **Data Retrieval:** SOS Inventory processes the request and sends back the updated transaction data to Method.

7. **Use of Method for CRM:** Method continues to be used for CRM purposes, such as managing new contacts and leads, while SOS handles inventory and sales transactions.

In both cases, integration was essential—but the reliance on manual refreshes or scheduled syncs made it clear that the current architecture lacks the real-time responsiveness users need during the sales cycle.

Common Themes Across Customer Workflows

Despite the differences in customizations, the following themes consistently emerged:

Real-Time Visibility is Non-Negotiable

All workflows underscore the need for accurate, real-time inventory data to support effective decision-making—whether during sales order creation or earlier in the sales pipeline.

Multi-Warehouse and Advanced Tracking Are Standard Expectations

All workflows underscore the need for accurate multi-warehouse management and detailed location based tracking, which are critical for complex inventory environments.

Minimizing Manual Processes

The workflows all highlighted the burden of manual interventions—like manually triggering updates for inventory or custom handling of warehouse data. Reducing these manual steps is critical to improving efficiency and lowering the risk of errors.

Integration Without Latency is the Goal

When integrations are necessary, they need to operate in real-time. The current dependence on QuickBooks or scheduled sync routines creates a disconnect that introduces latency and data discrepancies—especially problematic in high-volume or fast-moving inventory environments.

Complexity of Customization Needs

Customers consistently face complex workflows that require heavy customization. Whether it's adapting integrations with systems like SOS or building in-house solutions, each case shows that one-size-fits-all approaches fall short.

Summary: Why This Matters for Our Direction

These deep dives with the PS team highlighted that **neither pure native nor full integration alone can serve all use cases**. Some customers need a robust, fully native solution that works out-of-the-box. Others are ready to integrate, but only if it means real-time accuracy and fewer manual steps.

This feedback has played a critical role in shaping our thinking around the Native and Hybrid prototypes. It validates that:

- The **Native path** must support advanced inventory workflows without excessive customization.
- The **Hybrid path** must support seamless, real-time integration—without the friction of latency or data loss.

Competitive Research: How Other Platforms Approach Inventory Management

To complement our internal research and PS team insights, we conducted a competitive analysis of how leading CRM platforms implement inventory management—either natively or through third-party integrations. These insights will help inform our strategic direction in developing a native or hybrid solution.

> Goal: Identify how competing CRM's handle inventory management - specifically whether each provides native functionality or is reliant on third-party integrations.

CRM	Native Functionality	Third-Party Integration
Salesforce	❌ No dedicated inventory in core sales cloud. Basic inventory tracking via field services app.	✅ Katana (Via Zapier): Sales Order Imports via trigger or creation Zoho Inventory: contacts only Cin7: How Salesforce integrates with Cin7 Provides customers with up-to-date stock on hand, accurate pricing and detailed product information. Ensures customers receive their products when you promised, using Salesforce. Allows customers to easily order in Cin7 when your customer accepts the quote. Synchronizes order status in Salesforce and Cin7 with shipment status and tracking codes, for faster order processing and fulfillment.

Hubspot	❌ No native inventory management functionality.	✅ Katana Integration: Real-time inventory sync (Katana > Hubspot), Sales Order Imports via trigger or creation Zoho Inventory: Real-time two way sync, contacts only Cin7: Two way customer data sync
Monday. com	❌ Inventory tracking must be built via custom boards/workflows/templates. Not a native solution.	✅ Integrates with various platforms:
Copper CRM	❌ No native inventory management functionality.	❌ No integrations available with third-party inventory solutions
Zoho CRM	✅ Offers a full native inventory management solution called Zoho Inventory.	❌ No integrations available with third-party inventory solutions since they have their own native solution.
Pipedrive	❌ No native inventory management functionality. Includes product lists but does not track counts or movements.	✅ Katana (Via Zapier): Sales Order Imports via trigger or creation • FYI this integration is not found on Pipedrive integration catalogue
Less Annoying CRM	❌ No native inventory management functionality.	❌ No integrations available with third-party inventory solutions

Capsule CRM	❌ No native inventory management functionality. Can list products in opportunities, but no stock tracking functionality.	✅ Cin7: Syncs contacts
Freshsales (Freshworks CRM)	❌ No native inventory management functionality. Can list products in deals, but no stock tracking functionality.	❌ No integrations available with third-party inventory solutions
Insightly	❌ No native inventory management functionality. Can store product info and create quotes but does not track inventory counts.	❌ No integrations available with third-party inventory solutions

Among the CRM competitors analyzed, a clear trend emerges: **90%** do not offer native inventory management, with **50%** opting to integrate with external inventory solutions. Zoho stands out as the only CRM providing a robust, out-of-the-box native inventory solution. This divergence in strategy raises an important question: *Why do so many CRMs avoid building native inventory and rely on integrations instead, and what can Method learn from this?*

Strategic Focus: Core Competency Over All-in-One

Focusing on Core Strengths

Most CRM vendors deliberately steer clear of inventory management because it falls outside their front-office, customer-facing focus. Features like inventory tracking, fulfillment, and warehousing are typically seen as ERP domain functionality. Rather than dilute their product's clarity, platforms like HubSpot and Pipedrive choose to be best-in-class at sales, marketing, and customer management.

Avoiding Feature Creep

Building a native inventory system could turn a streamlined CRM into a bulky, complex product. CRM companies often differentiate themselves with simplicity and usability. Adding inventory management would introduce complexity that many CRM users don't need. Thus,

from a product strategy standpoint, it's safer to leave inventory features to specialized apps so the CRM can remain simple and intuitive for its primary use cases

Ecosystem and Differentiation

Rather than attempt to be an all-in-one software, many CRM platforms embrace an ecosystem strategy. They offer robust integration marketplaces and APIs, allowing customers to choose whichever inventory or ERP system fits their needs. This has several strategic benefits:

Partnering with Specialists:

- By integrating with dedicated inventory management software, CRMs can offer a combined solution without having to build or maintain it.
- This partnership approach means the CRM vendor can co-market with inventory software providers instead of competing with them.

Faster Time to Market:

- If customers demand inventory capabilities, it's quicker to integrate an existing solution than develop one from scratch.

Inventory Requirements Vary Widely

A single, one-size-fits-all inventory module often fails to meet the needs of diverse verticals—from manufacturing to field services to retail. Offering integrations gives customers the flexibility to choose systems tailored to their specific industry. This flexibility can be a selling point: the CRM can fit into many workflows without itself having to accommodate all those industry-specific needs.

Resource Allocation & ROI

It may be more profitable to integrate with the popular inventory apps that customers already use, rather than build a competing solution that only a fraction of the CRM's customers would adopt. In short, integrations let the CRM vendor say "yes, we connect to inventory management" without the cost of developing and maintaining a full solution in-house.

What This Means for Method's Prototype Direction

This research **strongly validates our Hybrid prototype approach**.

The overwhelming majority of CRM platforms avoid building native inventory management—not because the functionality isn't needed, but because integrations offer a more scalable, flexible, and sustainable way to support the diverse needs of inventory-based businesses. Our Hybrid prototype aligns perfectly with this model: providing core inventory capabilities natively, while

enabling seamless integration with third-party systems for businesses with more advanced requirements.

By adopting this Hybrid model, Method offers:

- A **solid foundation** for customers with simpler inventory needs, right out of the box.
- A **path to grow** into more advanced capabilities via integrations.
- A way to **serve a broader range of users/workflows**—from those who just need visibility at the sales order stage, to those requiring full inventory traceability and automation.

We also gathered feedback from both our Partner Network and PS team. Their responses overwhelmingly validated the Hybrid prototype approach as the most flexible and scalable path forward.

Partner Feedback

Jason Masina

> *"This looks great. I think it'll be a big hit. There's lots of customers using Method that would need something like this and that would use it."*

> *"If you're starting out without those advanced features, which is smart because you want to get out your MVP, I don't think it should have all the bells and whistles in your first iteration. So to include those integrations is good—because then people who are already using those advanced tools can continue using them but also use Method. So that's smart."*

Paulette Dreher

> *"Very nicely done! You are on the right path."*

> *"So you've kind of done both steps, which is awesome—because you can kind of pick and choose. Which is awesome because every single customer that you speak to is going to ask you for something different. So, I can't think of anything else than what you already have."*

PS Team Feedback

Thomas Darlington

> *“Some sort of hybrid option would definitely be useful.”*

> *“The hybrid with more options might be the better approach.”*

Joseph McDonald

> *“As far as how I see it in the future, I would think that probably the hybrid approach would make the most sense... There are so many ways you can model an inventory relationship... it’s almost impossible to have a perfect fit. So, variety feels like it would probably make the most sense.”*

Ryan Karaba

> *“I think Hybrid could work for lots of businesses that are willing to incur an additional cost.”*

This cross-functional validation reinforces that the Hybrid prototype is not only a practical path to market—but also one that meets the nuanced, evolving needs of our users.

Conclusion

In a space where most CRMs have drawn the line at inventory, Method’s Hybrid prototype bridges the gap—offering customers the flexibility they expect, with the usability they deserve. By grounding our prototypes in real-world user needs and industry patterns, we’re not just building a competitive solution, but one that is practical, scalable, and strategically positioned for growth in 2025 and beyond.